

GRADE 8 · READING LITERATURE · RL.8.4

What the Order Didn't Say

Determine figurative and connotative meanings of words and phrases in a literary text, and analyze how specific word choices shape meaning and tone.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RL.8.4: Determine figurative and connotative meanings of words and phrases in ...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Denotation is a word's dictionary meaning; connotation is the feeling or association it carries beyond that meaning. Figurative language (metaphor, simile, personification) means something beyond its literal words. At grade 8, comparing word choices across two texts about the same event is a powerful way to see how word choice alone can create very different tones.

Modeled Example

Compare the connotation of "the family relocated" versus "the family fled." Both can describe the same event — how do the connotations differ?

"Relocated" carries a calm, planned, even bureaucratic connotation, suggesting control and choice, while "fled" carries urgency and fear, suggesting the family had little choice and left in danger.

In the phrase "the smoke crawled over the ridge like something that knew where it was going," what figurative device is used, and what tone does it create?

This is a simile (and personification, since smoke is given intention), and it creates an ominous, threatening tone by making the smoke seem deliberate and predatory rather than simply a natural weather event.

Evacuation Order 14-B

RIDGELINE COUNTY OFFICE OF EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT ■ EVACUATION ORDER 14-B ■ Effective immediately, all residents of Zones 3 through 6 are directed to relocate to designated shelters. Residents should gather essential documents and medications and proceed to Route 9 southbound. Non-compliance may result in restricted emergency service access. This order remains in effect until further notice.

What the Order Didn't Say

1. The order came through Priya's phone at 6:14 a.m., a flat gray banner with no exclamation points, no color, nothing to suggest it was the reason her mother was already dragging the fireproof document box down the stairs two at a time. "Relocate to designated shelters." As if the house were a piece of furniture they were simply moving to a different room.

2. Outside, the sky had turned a color Priya had never had a word for before that morning — not orange exactly, more like the inside of a bruise, and the smoke crawled over the ridge like something that knew where it was going. The order had called it "reduced visibility due to active conditions." Priya thought that was like calling a wildfire "a warm afternoon."

3. Her little brother, Theo, wanted to know if their house counted as "essential documents." Their mother said no, gently, the kind of gentle that Priya recognized as the sound of someone keeping a much louder feeling folded up small. Theo asked again anyway, holding his stuffed rabbit like it might answer for him.

What the Order Didn't Say, continued

4. They joined Route 9 southbound along with what felt like the entire ridge, headlights strung out ahead of them like a sentence with no punctuation, just comma after comma of red taillights with no end in sight. The order had said "proceed." It had not said anything about the woman two cars ahead who kept getting out to look back at the smoke, or the way the radio DJ's voice cracked once, just once, before he caught it and went back to reciting the shelter addresses in his steady announcer voice.

5. "Restricted emergency service access," the order had warned, if they did not comply. Priya turned the phrase over and over. It sounded like a rule about a parking lot, not a sentence about whether help would come if they stayed. She understood, suddenly and completely, that the order had been written by someone whose job was to be understood by everyone, and that being understood by everyone sometimes meant sounding like it mattered to no one.

6. At the shelter, a volunteer handed them water bottles and said, "You're safe now," and that phrase, unlike anything in the order, was the first thing all morning that had sounded like it was written for Priya specifically, and not for Zones 3 through 6.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit phrase does the official order use to describe leaving one's home, according to paragraph 1?
2. What is the connotation of "relocate" as Priya interprets it in paragraph 1, and how does that differ from what is actually happening?

Guided Practice

3. Identify the simile in paragraph 2 describing the smoke, and explain what it suggests about the smoke's behavior.

4. How does Priya's comparison in paragraph 2 ("calling a wildfire 'a warm afternoon'") reveal her opinion of the order's word choice?

Guided Practice

5. What does the phrase "the kind of gentle that Priya recognized as the sound of someone keeping a much louder feeling folded up small" suggest about their mother's emotional state?

6. Identify the figurative comparison in paragraph 4 describing the traffic, and explain what it conveys about the scene.

Partner Discussion

7. What two specific incidents in paragraph 4 does the narrator note that the official order's language never captures?

8. What is the denotative meaning of "restricted emergency service access," and what connotation does Priya sense underneath it in paragraph 5?

Partner Discussion

9. Why does Priya compare the phrase "restricted emergency service access" to "a rule about a parking lot"?

Independent Practice

10. What insight does Priya reach in paragraph 5 about why the order is written the way it is?

11. How does the volunteer's phrase "You're safe now" in paragraph 6 contrast in tone with the official order's language throughout the story?

Independent Practice

12. Why does the narrator specifically note that the volunteer's phrase felt "written for Priya specifically, and not for Zones 3 through 6"?

13. Compare the tone of the official order text to the tone of Priya's narrative. Use one word-choice example from each to support your comparison.

Independent Practice

14. Choose one phrase from the official order and explain how its word choice avoids alarming readers, even though the situation is dangerous.

15. If the order had instead said "a dangerous wildfire is approaching your home," how might the tone and effect on residents be different from the actual order's wording?

Small-Group Work

16. What is the denotative meaning of "reduced visibility due to active conditions," and what does Priya believe it is designed to avoid saying directly?

17. Identify the figurative language in "a color Priya had never had a word for before that morning — not orange exactly, more like the inside of a bruise," and explain what feeling it conveys.

Small-Group Work

18. Why might the author have chosen to include the official order as a separate, first text before Priya's narrative, rather than only telling the story from Priya's point of view?

19. Choose one word from the official order and explain both its technical/denotative meaning and the connotation it might carry for a frightened resident.

Exit Ticket

20. Trace how the story's tone shifts from paragraph 1 to paragraph 6, citing specific word choices at the beginning and end.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. "Relocate to designated shelters."

2. Priya interprets "relocate" as sounding calm and administrative, like moving furniture to a different room, when the actual event is an urgent, frightening evacuation from danger.

3. "The smoke crawled over the ridge like something that knew where it was going" is a simile that suggests intention and menace, as if the smoke were a living thing deliberately advancing rather than simply spreading with the wind.

4. It reveals she thinks the order's phrase "reduced visibility due to active conditions" dangerously understates the danger, comparing it to an equally absurd understatement of a wildfire as pleasant weather.

5. It suggests their mother is suppressing fear or panic beneath a calm exterior for Theo's sake, and that her gentleness is a controlled performance rather than an absence of strong feeling.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. The headlights are compared to "a sentence with no punctuation, just comma after comma of red taillights with no end in sight," conveying an overwhelming, unending line of evacuating cars with no clear resolution in sight.

7. A woman two cars ahead repeatedly getting out to look back at the smoke, and a radio DJ's voice cracking once before he composes himself and continues reciting shelter addresses.

8. Denotatively, it means emergency responders may not be able to reach non-compliant residents; Priya senses underneath it the real, frightening possibility that help might not come at all, though the phrase itself sounds bureaucratic and mild.

9. She makes this comparison to highlight how mismatched the phrase's mild, procedural tone is to the life-or-death situation it actually describes.

10. She realizes the order was written to be understood by everyone equally, and that this kind of universal, neutral language can end up sounding like it matters to no one in particular, even though it is meant for everyone.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. Unlike the order's flat, procedural phrases, the volunteer's words are warm and personal, addressed to Priya specifically rather than to an entire numbered zone, creating a tone of individual care instead of bureaucratic instruction.

12. It emphasizes the story's larger point about word choice and tone: official, general language can technically communicate the same information as warm, specific language, but it does not make a listener feel seen or cared for the way personal language does.

13. The order's tone is flat and procedural, shown by phrases like "proceed to Route 9 southbound"; Priya's narrative is vivid and emotional, shown by figurative language like comparing the smoke to something that "knew where it was going."

14. "Reduced visibility due to active conditions" avoids words like "fire," "danger," or "smoke," using vague, technical-sounding language that describes a hazardous situation without naming it directly, which likely reduces panic but also reduces urgency.

15. It would create a more urgent, alarming tone that clearly names the danger, which might prompt faster compliance from residents but could also risk causing panic that the order's calmer, more procedural language was likely designed to avoid.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. Denotatively, it means smoke is making it hard to see, caused by the fire's ongoing spread; Priya believes it is designed to avoid saying "wildfire" or "fire" directly, softening the danger through vague, technical phrasing.

17. The comparison of the sky to "the inside of a bruise" is a simile that conveys a sickly, painful, unnatural feeling, suggesting the sky itself looks injured or wrong.

18. Presenting the order's flat, procedural language first lets readers directly compare its tone to Priya's vivid, emotional narrative that follows, making the contrast in word choice and tone much clearer than if only one version were given.

19. Answers vary; for example, "designated" technically just means officially assigned or specified, but to a frightened resident it might carry a connotation of cold, impersonal bureaucracy at a moment of personal crisis.

20. The story begins with a flat, confused tone as Priya reads the bureaucratic order ("relocate to designated shelters," paragraph 1) and ends with a warmer, more personal tone at the shelter, when the volunteer's words "You're safe now" (paragraph 6) finally sound, in Priya's words, "written for Priya specifically."

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer